

CHIEF INVESTMENT OFFICE

Capital Market Outlook

September 8, 2026

All data, projections and opinions are as of the date of this report and subject to change.

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Macro Strategy—Commodities: From Inflation Hedge to Structural Growth Asset:

The investment case for commodities is shifting from a narrow, tactical role as an inflation hedge toward a broader, potentially strategic portfolio allocation. In addition to offering differentiated return behavior when stock and bond correlations rise, commodities can provide exposure to structural growth drivers including Artificial Intelligence (AI) infrastructure, electrification, energy security, reshoring, and supply-chain investment.

Because the supply of many critical materials is slow to respond and geographically concentrated, these demand trends may create persistent scarcity and pricing power, although cyclical volatility remains an important consideration.

Market View—Rising Global Interest Rates and International Markets: Strong earnings growth has so far delivered a fourth consecutive year of double-digit gains for global Equity indexes in 2026, propelling them to new all-time highs. But a growing risk throughout the year has been the increase in government bond yields, which have also broken out to multidecade highs across a number of the major markets.

The U.S. Treasury will this week begin its expanded Treasury securities buyback program announced in mid-August in response to rising rates. But 10-year yields across all the major G10 countries have moved higher, in many cases by as much as or more than in the U.S. market.

Thought of the Week—The One-Offs Inflating Q2 Earnings: Second quarter corporate earnings results were boosted by one-offs, including mark-to-market gains on private investments and refunds following the tariff ruling. Yet even beyond these one-off factors, the Q2 underlying picture remains healthy: Companies have demonstrated an ability to grow revenues and maintain historically high margins in aggregate, as 10 of 11 sectors posted earnings growth.

That's a challenging setup for earnings next year. But for now, strong fundamentals and broad-based earnings participation continue to provide support for Equities, helping offset concerns of rising yields.

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Portfolio Considerations

Despite ongoing market concerns around rates, valuations, and geopolitics, we remain constructive on risk assets, citing improving manufacturing activity, accelerating AI investment, resilient consumers, rising earnings, and ample liquidity as support for continued economic expansion.

Accordingly, we maintain our overweight to U.S. Equities, favoring diversification with meaningful bond allocations, and views market volatility as a potential opportunity to rebalance and add risk selectively.

As market leadership broadens, this month we are increasing exposure to Industrials, Financials and Healthcare while funding those moves by reducing Consumer Discretionary, Consumer Staples and Utilities.

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Commodities: From Inflation Hedge to Structural Growth Asset

*Anna Snider, Managing Director and Head of Investment Manager Selection
(Due Diligence)*

A broader role in portfolios: For decades, commodities occupied a relatively narrow role in portfolios: protection against inflation when rising prices eroded the value of traditional assets. That function remains important, but the investment case is broadening. Commodities now sit at the intersection of geopolitical fragmentation, supply-chain security, reshoring, inventory rebuilding, and the buildout of AI and digital infrastructure. Together, these forces are turning parts of the asset class from purely cyclical exposures into potential long-term growth beneficiaries.

The diversification case is also becoming more relevant. In Q1, when inflation concerns peaked, the Bloomberg Commodity Index returned close to 25%, outperforming both Equities and Fixed Income. At the same time, the relationship among major asset classes has shifted. Equity and Fixed Income correlations have tightened in recent years, while commodities have moved in the opposite direction: over the trailing five years, their correlation with both Equities and bonds has been negative. That combination of inflation sensitivity and differentiated return behavior can make commodities useful beyond a simple tactical hedge.

AI infrastructure is a physical buildout: AI is often viewed through semiconductors, software platforms, and hyperscale data centers. Yet the infrastructure required to deploy AI is extraordinarily commodity intensive. It requires continuous electricity, generation capacity, transmission lines, substations, transformers, cooling systems, networking hardware and structural materials. In that sense, AI is not only a computing revolution. It is also an energy, infrastructure, and critical-materials investment cycle.

Power is the first constraint. Data centers require reliable, around-the-clock electricity. Natural gas remains a practical source of incremental generation in the U.S., while nuclear power is emerging as a strategic long-term option for hyperscalers seeking stable baseload supply. Solar and wind can add capacity and support decarbonization goals, but grid reliability and storage become more important as power demand rises. That supports investment in batteries, backup power and grid-scale storage, with lithium and graphite among the relevant inputs.

The buildout also increases demand for industrial metals. Copper is a clear beneficiary because it is essential to transmission, transformers, cooling systems and data-center wiring. Aluminum and iron ore are used in facilities, electrical equipment, transmission networks and supporting infrastructure. Semiconductor fabrication adds another layer of demand through industrial gases such as helium and neon, high-purity quartz for wafers and optics, and gallium and germanium for advanced chips, photonics, and telecommunications. AI-enabled automation and robotics also depend on permanent magnets that use rare earth elements, including neodymium-praseodymium and dysprosium-terbium.

Demand has moved faster than supply: This demand surge resembles earlier cycles in semiconductors and memory, where expectations pulled spending forward. Metals and mining companies are already seeing earnings growth and margin expansion, yet the industry has struggled to keep pace with demand. The imbalance matters because commodity supply is slow to respond. Production of many strategic materials is geographically concentrated, permitting timelines are lengthy, recycling capacity is limited, and substitution can remain years from commercial viability. New mines and processing facilities can take a decade or more to reach production.

Investment Implications

Commodities may increasingly serve three portfolio purposes: inflation protection, diversification from traditional assets, and participation in long-term infrastructure and resource-demand growth, supporting a diversified allocation across direct commodities and select producer Equities rather than a single directional trade.

Governments are also taking a larger role through industrial policy, export controls, stockpiling and efforts to secure critical supply chains. Restrictions involving gallium, germanium, graphite and other strategic materials underscore how geopolitics can affect availability and pricing. As a result, the current cycle may produce greater scarcity and pricing power than demand growth alone would suggest.

So far, this dynamic has been most visible in industrial metals, but the same forces could extend into agriculture. Reshoring changes where food and inputs are produced and processed, while inventory rebuilding can lift demand for fertilizer, fuel, machinery and storage. Agriculture has not yet experienced the same earnings and pricing impact as metals, but supply-chain resilience could make it a broader beneficiary over time.

Cyclical forces still matter: The structural thesis does not eliminate near-term volatility. Energy remains a key transmission mechanism for inflation because oil and natural gas underpin transportation, manufacturing and industrial production. Geopolitical disruptions can cascade through supply chains, raising costs and moving both commodity futures and spot prices. Currency dynamics matter as well. A stronger U.S. dollar can restrain commodity prices by increasing costs for non-U.S. buyers, while renewed dollar weakness could support emerging-market demand and reprice dollar-denominated assets.

A stabilization of geopolitical tensions could create a more constructive cyclical backdrop through lower energy volatility, improved business confidence and stronger capital investment. Conversely, renewed conflict can produce sharp and uneven moves across the complex. These crosscurrents reinforce the value of treating commodities as a diversified allocation rather than a single directional trade.

Gold, implementation and the portfolio case: Gold is fundamentally different from most industrial commodities, but it deserves attention. Its traditional relationships with interest rates and the dollar have been less reliable lately. Even so, sustained central bank and exchange-traded fund buying points to durable long-term demand despite bouts of volatility such as the selloff earlier this year. Gold also tended to move inversely with oil during the height of the Iran conflict, illustrating how different commodities can respond differently to the same geopolitical shock.

Investors can access the theme through commodity futures or producer Equities. Direct commodity exposure is generally the clearer vehicle for inflation protection, scarcity, and geopolitical supply shocks. Producer equities can offer greater upside when commodity prices rise faster than operating costs because earnings and margins expand, but that leverage is asymmetric. Company-specific execution, financing, cost and valuation risks can still cause Equities to underperform the underlying commodity. A blended approach may capture both physical scarcity and corporate operating leverage.

Ultimately, commodities remain sensitive to energy markets, currencies, growth, and geopolitics, but their portfolio role is expanding. They can provide inflation protection and diversification while offering exposure to AI infrastructure, electrification, energy security, defense modernization, reshoring and, potentially, agricultural supply-chain investment. The strongest beneficiaries of the AI trade may therefore extend well beyond technology companies to the materials and power systems that make deployment possible.

Rising Global Interest Rates and International Markets

Ehiwario Efeiyini, Director and Senior Investment Strategist

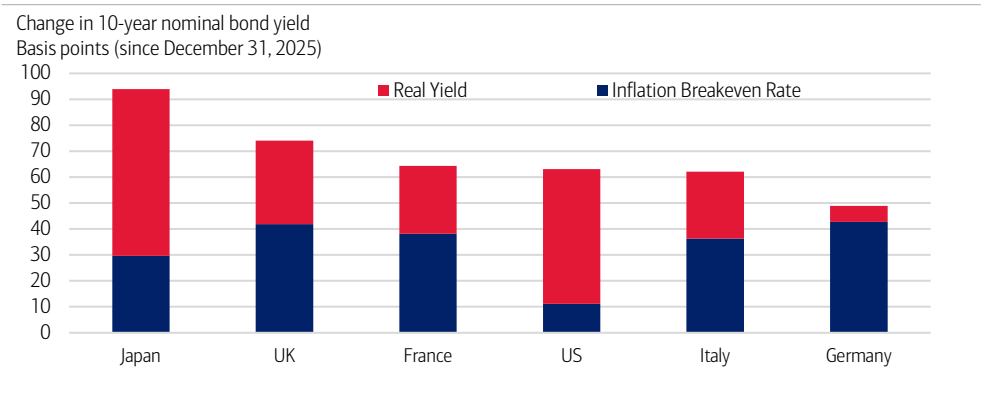
Strong earnings growth has so far delivered a fourth consecutive year of double-digit gains for global Equity indexes in 2026, propelling them to new all-time highs. But a growing risk throughout the year has been the increase in government bond yields, which have also broken out to multi-decade highs across a number of the major markets. The U.S. Treasury will this week begin its expanded Treasury securities buyback program announced in mid-August in response to rising rates. But 10-year yields across all the major G10 countries have moved higher, in many cases by as much as or more than in the U.S. market. Against a backdrop of above-trend growth in nominal gross domestic product (GDP), high energy prices and elevated inflation, investors appear to be reassessing monetary policy expectations, particularly in Europe where most of the 2026 increase in 10-year yields has been driven by inflation breakevens (Exhibit 1). Fixed Income markets are consequently looking for policy rate hikes from the European Central Bank later this week and potentially from the Bank of Japan later next month.

The rise in global interest rates has also come alongside an expansion in fiscal policy across the major markets. In Europe, 2026 and 2027 are expected to be the peak spending years for defense and infrastructure expenditure plans unveiled last year. The so-called Readiness 2030 package allocates €800 billion to increased European Union defense spending as it looks to move toward its 5% of GDP target by 2035. And at the same time, the German government relaxation of its national debt brake has directed €500 billion toward funding for investment in clean energy, transportation and digital infrastructure. Similarly in Japan, the government supermajority is looking to enact a new stimulus aimed at raising investment levels across 17 strategic sectors such as semiconductors, defense and shipbuilding, in addition to a planned two-year cut to the consumption tax on food from April 2027. And in the UK, the new central government leadership is also likely to announce new spending measures when its first national budget is released next month. To the extent that increased public investment spending can lift productivity and support nominal GDP growth in Europe and Japan, the rise in yields need not undermine economic growth or derail the equity market advance. But higher rates, especially in response to supply-driven energy price inflation, nonetheless remain a risk for developed market equity returns going into the end of the year.

Investment Implications

Ongoing strength in economic growth and corporate earnings should support global equity markets even in the face of rising rates. For Emerging Markets (EM) Equities in particular, contained inflation, flat to lower local policy rate expectations and stronger fundamentals should limit the impact. And we continue to favor EM Equities over International Developed Markets, where inflation levels are generally still above target, central banks are expected to raise rates and investors will be watching for fiscal sustainability as governments implement expansionary budget plans.

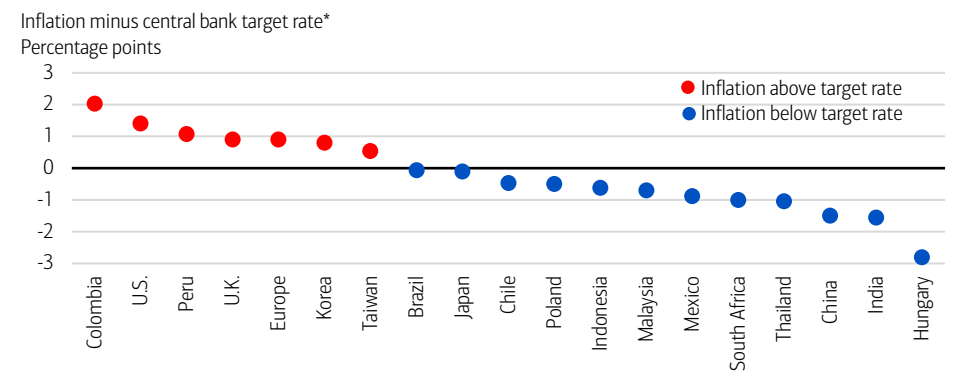
Exhibit 1: Global Bond Yields in Major Markets have Risen by as Much or More than U.S. Yields in 2026.



Source: Bloomberg. Data as of September 1, 2026..

For many emerging markets the picture looks quite different. In contrast with the U.S., Japan and Europe, inflation rates are generally well below central bank targets outside a limited number of resource exporters in Latin America and the booming AI-linked economies of Korea and Taiwan (Exhibit 2). As a result, policy rate expectations over the coming quarters are stable or lower for several emerging markets (including China, Malaysia, Thailand, Poland, Brazil and Mexico) according to Bloomberg consensus forecasts.

Exhibit 2: Inflation a Greater Challenge for Central Banks in Developed Markets than EMs.



Source: Bloomberg. Data as of July 2026. *Central bank inflation targets are the upper bound when set as a range.

Historically, rising U.S. interest rates have been a major headwind for emerging markets. But looking ahead in the current cycle, we still expect the impact of potential Federal Reserve (Fed) rate hikes to be lower than in the past. Over recent years, the association between tighter Fed policy and weaker EM returns appears to have diminished. EM Equities for example were resilient in the face of aggressive U.S. rate increases in 2022 and 2023, broadly keeping pace with the rest of the world. This is in sharp contrast to prior cycles in which tighter Fed policy has resulted in capital flight, deleveraging and falling asset values across the emerging world. Particularly during the crisis periods of the 1980s and 1990s—but also more recently during the 2015 taper tantrum—U.S. monetary tightening has tended to attract capital away from riskier emerging countries (particularly those with large current account deficits), reducing support for local asset prices and exchange rates.

Associated strength in the U.S. dollar has typically been an additional hurdle. For those emerging economies with fixed exchange rates, a loss of export competitiveness has further undermined current account positions, forcing central banks to run down their foreign exchange reserves. And where exchange rates are floating, foreign currency debts have risen in local currency terms, resulting in widespread defaults, debt downgrades, recessions and additional exchange rate depreciation.

But starting in the years that followed the 1997-1998 Asian financial crisis and continuing into the current cycle, the fundamentals across much of the EM universe have improved. Fixed exchange rates have been abandoned. EM foreign currency reserves have roughly doubled as a share of GDP. The share of EM debt denominated in U.S. dollars has fallen significantly, led by the private sector across households and corporates. And for most countries, current account deficits have narrowed or disappeared entirely. As a result, emerging markets have become much more insulated from the direction of U.S. interest rates on a structural basis, and this has only been reinforced by the AI-driven revaluation of key Asian markets in 2026. Greater concentration in Korea and Taiwan has increased the EM weighting in the surplus Asia-Pacific region to 83% as at the end of August—up from 81% at the start of the year and 71% a decade ago.

Above-trend growth in nominal GDP and ongoing strength in corporate earnings should support global equity markets even in the face of rising interest rates. But for emerging Equities in particular, contained inflation relative to central bank targets, flat to lower local policy rate expectations and stronger economic fundamentals should limit the impact from higher global rates. We continue to favor EM Equities over International Developed Markets, where inflation levels are generally still above target, central banks are expected to raise interest rates and investors will be watching for fiscal sustainability as governments implement expansionary budget plans.

The One-Offs Inflating Q2 Earnings

Lauren Sanfilippo, *Director and Senior Investment Strategist*

Headline Q2 earnings numbers look almost too good to be true. And in a sense, they are. With nearly all of S&P 500 companies' results reported, EPS growth is tracking around 50% year-over-year (YoY)—not just an acceleration from Q1 but a second consecutive quarter above 20%. Chiefly skewing the headline number are massive mark-to-market gains on private investments for a handful of mega cap technology companies like Alphabet and Amazon that booked outsized non-operating gains tied to their stakes in Anthropic, while Microsoft benefited from its OpenAI investment. Strip those out, and adjusted EPS growth notches down to 31%. The point being, after being sliced and diced, 30%+ is well above any long-run historical earnings growth rate.

The one-off nature of earnings strength wasn't limited to investment gains. A second, less-discussed boost was tariff refunds. As Exhibit 3 illustrates, revenues from tariffs steadily climbed from early 2025 through mid-2026 until the International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA) tariff ruling which initiated the refund process. As refunds were disbursed, customs receipts turned net negative in June and July, with refund payments exceeding total tariff collections. Customs and Border Protection cash withdrawals of more than \$100 billion in refunds have now been paid—60% of the \$165 billion in total eligible claims.

The recipients: the “importers of record,” or the dozens of S&P 500 companies that have disclosed billions in refunds over the past two quarters; Apple alone received \$2.19 billion, adding \$0.11 to per-share earnings to their quarter. Other disclosed refunds include Nike with \$986 million, Amazon with \$640 million, and General Motors refunded \$500 million (although accounting treatment and use of proceeds has varied).

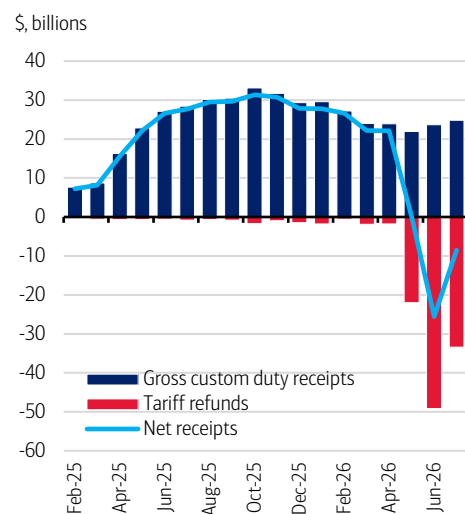
The boost of investment gains and/or refunds may not be repeatable in future quarters. Perhaps more telling is that the median company's revenue grew roughly 15% YoY, the strongest gain in years, corroborating that there is operating momentum rather than just an accounting mirage for Q2 earnings. Margins, too, as a percent of GDP are at their highest back to 1950, hovering north of 22%, see Exhibit 4. That this is occurring amid rising rates and at a time of geopolitical uncertainty/disruption, rather than a post-recessionary recovery, makes the results that much more impressive.

The Path Forward: Questions remain about the sustainability of these elevated growth rates, although consensus expects EPS growth to stay above 20% in both Q3 and Q4. If achieved, every quarter this year would see 20%-plus EPS growth. On the back of brighter outlooks from Corporate America in recent weeks, full-year earnings growth will decelerate into the mid-teens in 2027, but that moderation comes off a high base of 2026. For now, the breadth of earnings growth is the encouraging story as 10 of the 11 sectors reported growth (Energy and Communication Services leading the way, Healthcare the only detractor). That's a reflection of strong core businesses growing revenues into 2027's tougher YoY comparisons.

Investment Implications

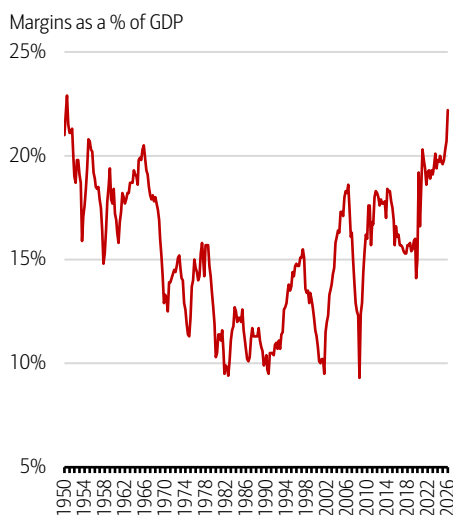
Underlying earnings-per-share (EPS) growth of around 30%, stripped of investment gains, is historically exceptional. It remains that robust corporate earnings and positive revisions have helped Equities absorb concerns around the recent rise in yields.

Exhibit 3: The Tariff Give and Take.



Sources: U.S. Treasury; Haver Analytics. Data through July 2026, as of August 24, 2026.

Exhibit 4: Domestic Margins Approach All-Time High.



Sources: Bureau of Economic Analysis; Haver Analytics. Data as of September 1, 2026.

Equities

Equities	Total Return in USD (%)			
	Current	WTD	MTD	YTD
DJIA	53,414.25	-0.2	0.5	12.4
NASDAQ	26,506.99	0.4	0.5	14.5
S&P 500	7,718.60	0.1	0.5	13.7
S&P 400 Mid Cap	3,784.99	0.2	0.7	15.5
Russell 2000	2,975.65	0.2	0.7	20.8
MSCI World	4,986.93	0.1	0.4	13.6
MSCI EAFE	3,239.16	-0.2	0.2	14.1
MSCI Emerging Markets	1,726.32	0.3	0.4	24.6

Fixed Income†

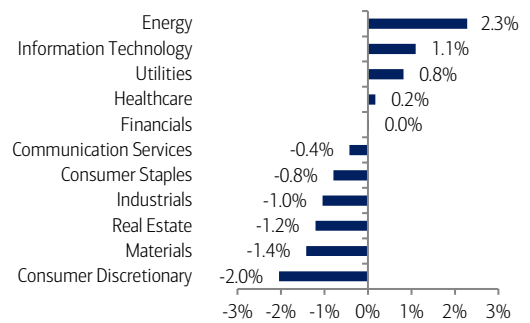
Fixed Income	Total Return in USD (%)			
	Current	WTD	MTD	YTD
Corporate & Government	4.96	-0.19	-0.12	-0.57
Agencies	4.68	-0.04	-0.04	0.41
Municipals	4.07	-0.81	-0.52	-0.33
U.S. Investment-Grade Credit	5.04	-0.18	-0.09	-0.40
International	5.54	-0.29	-0.20	-0.60
High Yield	7.37	-0.15	-0.12	2.57
90 Day Yield	3.84	3.80	3.83	3.63
2 Year Yield	4.37	4.34	4.34	3.47
10 Year Yield	4.78	4.72	4.75	4.17
30 Year Yield	5.24	5.21	5.24	4.84

Commodities & Currencies

Commodities	Total Return in USD (%)			
	Current	WTD	MTD	YTD
Bloomberg Commodity	368.84	2.0	1.1	33.5
WTI Crude \$/Barrel††	91.48	9.7	6.7	59.3
Gold Spot \$/Ounce††	4429.98	-0.6	-0.2	2.6

Currencies	Total Return in USD (%)			
	Current	Prior Week End	Prior Month End	2025 Year End
EUR/USD	1.16	1.16	1.16	1.17
USD/JPY	156.26	160.09	159.74	156.71
USD/CNH	6.71	6.73	6.72	6.98

S&P Sector Returns



Sources: Bloomberg, Factset. Total Returns from the period of 8/31/2026 to 9/4/2026. †Bloomberg Barclays Indices. ††Spot price returns. All data as of the 9/4/2026 close. Data would differ if a different time period was displayed. Short-term performance shown to illustrate more recent trend. **Past performance is no guarantee of future results.**

Economic Forecasts (as of 9/4/2026)

Economic Forecasts	Q1 2026A	Q2 2026A	Q3 2026E	Q4 2026E	2026E	2027E
Real global GDP (% y/y annualized)	-	-	-	-	3.2	3.4
Real U.S. GDP (% q/q annualized)	2.1	1.5	2.5	2.4	2.1	2.2
CPI inflation (% y/y)	2.7	3.8	3.2	2.9	3.2	2.0
Core CPI inflation (% y/y)	2.5	2.7	2.4	2.5	2.5	2.5
Unemployment rate (%)	4.3	4.3	4.2	4.2	4.2	4.2
Fed funds rate, end period (%)	3.63	3.63	3.88	4.38	4.38	4.38

The forecasts in the table above are the base line view from BofA Global Research. The Global Wealth & Investment Management (GWIM) Investment Strategy Committee (ISC) may make adjustments to this view over the course of the year and can express upside/downside to these forecasts. Historical data is sourced from Bloomberg, FactSet, and Haver Analytics. **There can be no assurance that the forecasts will be achieved. Economic or financial forecasts are inherently limited and should not be relied on as indicators of future investment performance.** A = Actual. E/* = Estimate. Data as of September 4, 2026. Sources: BofA Global Research; GWIM ISC as of September 4, 2026.

Asset Class Weightings (as of 9/2/2026)

Asset Class	CIO View		
	Underweight	Neutral	Overweight
Global Equities	•	•	•
U.S. Large-cap Growth	•	•	•
U.S. Large-cap Value	•	•	•
U.S. Small-cap Growth	•	•	•
U.S. Small-cap Value	•	•	•
International Developed	•	•	•
Emerging Markets	•	•	•
Global Fixed Income	•	•	•
U.S. Governments	•	•	•
U.S. Mortgages	•	•	•
U.S. Corporates	•	•	•
International Fixed Income	•	•	•
High Yield	•	•	•
U.S. Investment-grade Tax Exempt	•	•	•
U.S. High Yield Tax Exempt	•	•	•
Alternative Investments*			
Hedge Strategies			
Private Equity			
Private Credit			
Real Assets			
Cash			

CIO Equity Sector Views

Sector	CIO View		
	Underweight	Neutral	Overweight
Industrials	•	•	•
Financials	•	•	•
Healthcare	•	•	•
Consumer Discretionary	•	•	•
Information Technology	•	•	•
Energy	•	•	•
Materials	•	•	•
Utilities	•	•	•
Communication Services	•	•	•
Real Estate	•	•	•
Consumer Staples	•	•	•

* Many products that pursue Alternative Investment strategies, specifically Private Equity and Hedge Funds, are available only to qualified investors. CIO asset class views are relative to the CIO Strategic Asset Allocation (SAA) of a multi-asset portfolio. Source: Chief Investment Office as of September 2, 2026. All sector and asset allocation recommendations must be considered in the context of an individual investor's goals, time horizon, liquidity needs and risk tolerance. Not all recommendations will be in the best interest of all investors.

Index Definitions

Securities indexes assume reinvestment of all distributions and interest payments. Indexes are unmanaged and do not take into account fees or expenses. It is not possible to invest directly in an index. Indexes are all based in U.S. dollars.

S&P 500 Index is a stock market index tracking the stock performance of 500 leading companies listed on stock exchanges in the United States.

Bloomberg Commodity Index tracks prices of futures contracts on physical commodities on the commodity markets.

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Alternative investments are speculative and involve a high degree of risk.

Alternative investments are intended for qualified investors only. Alternative Investments such as derivatives, hedge funds, private credit, private equity funds, and funds of funds can result in higher return potential but also higher loss potential. Changes in economic conditions or other circumstances may adversely affect your investments. Before you invest in alternative investments, you should consider your overall financial situation, how much money you have to invest, your need for liquidity, and your tolerance for risk.

Nonfinancial assets, such as closely held businesses, real estate, fine art, oil, gas and mineral properties, and timber, farm and ranch land, are complex in nature and involve risks including total loss of value. Special risk considerations include natural events (for example, earthquakes or fires), complex tax considerations, and lack of liquidity. Nonfinancial assets are not in the best interest of all investors. Always consult with your independent attorney, tax advisor, investment manager, and insurance agent for final recommendations and before changing or implementing any financial, tax, or estate planning strategy.

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